# The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

**Israel** rejected a ceasefire proposal by **Hamas** because it was based on “unrealistic demands”. The offer, reported by *Reuters*, was based on a two-stage agreement where Israeli women, children and elderly prisoners would be released first in exchange for more than 700 Palestinian prisoners. The second stage would see discussions of a permanent ceasefire and the withdrawal of Israeli forces in **Gaza**.

**Russia** launched a missile attack on **Odessa**, a Ukrainian city on the Black Sea coast, killing at least 14 people and injuring more than 45. The city has often been targeted by Russia due to its tactical, symbolic and economic significance. It is home to a vast port, vital to Ukraine’s Black Sea exports.

**Israel’s** ambassador to **America**, Michael Herzog, rebuked Chuck Schumer, the Democratic Senate majority leader and America’s highest-ranking Jewish politician. Mr Schumer had called on Israel to hold fresh elections as its government “no longer fits the needs of Israel” and said that the government of Binyamin Netanyahu tolerates too many civilian deaths in Gaza. Mr Herzog called his remarks “counterproductive”.

House prices in **China’s** “tier-one” cities fell by 0.3% in February, their eighth consecutive monthly fall. Despite there being no sign that the country’s property crisis is abating, the government appears reluctant to do enough to deal with the problems roiling the sector. Millions of Chinese have paid for apartments that indebted property firms have yet to deliver.

**Honda** and **Nissan** announced that they are exploring making **electric vehicles** together to help them compete with Chinese

carmakers. The scope of the partnership is not yet clear but Japan's second- and third-largest carmakers would potentially collaborate on artificial intelligence and producing key components. Japanese carmakers are struggling to break into the EV market.

**Argentina's** senate rejected a decree brought in by Javier Milei, the country's libertarian president, after he took office in December to deregulate the economy. The lower house must now vote on the issue, with the decree remaining in place until then. Mr Milei wants to alter or remove more than 300 regulations in sectors ranging from the housing-rental market to pharmaceuticals. He campaigned on taking a "chainsaw" to Argentina's bloated state.

The judge overseeing **Donald Trump**'s racketeering case in Georgia ruled that Fani Willis, the district attorney, can continue to lead the effort as long as the special prosecutor she hired—with whom she had an affair—steps aside. The judge found that the relationship produced an "appearance of impropriety" but no "actual conflict". Ms Willis' case would have faced extensive delays had she been forced off of it.

**Figure of the day:** $35bn, the amount the United Arab Emirates recently pledged to invest in Egypt. Read the full story.

*In the run-up to America's presidential election, we've launched The US in brief—a daily update to help you keep on top of the political stories that matter. Sign up here to receive it as a newsletter, each weekday, in your inbox.*

Photo: AP

## American consumers’ so-so sentiment

Their extreme gloom has dissipated, but Americans are still far from enthused by the economy. The latest reading of the University of Michigan’s consumer sentiment index—a closely watched indicator—will be released on Friday.

Last month the index dipped to 76.9—a level historically consistent with weak growth. That was down slightly from the start of the year, though up strongly from early 2023. For the Biden administration, the public mood has been a source of frustration. America’s recent economic growth has been impressive, but many people still seem more focused on high inflation than on the strong labour market. Analysts argue that political partisanship may be clouding survey responses and that it will take a while longer for people to digest the surge in prices that hit primarily in 2022. In this context a modest improvement in sentiment may be the best Joe Biden can hope for.

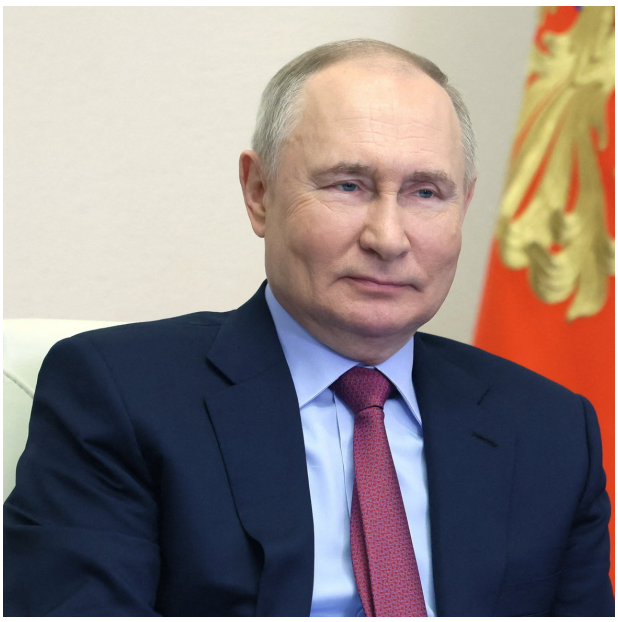

Photo: Getty Images

## Russia’s sham election

On Friday voting began in Russia’s presidential election. The result is not in doubt: Vladimir Putin will win another six-year term. He controls the media and has closed civil-society groups. (Golos, Russia’s only independent election-monitoring organisation, has been designated a “foreign agent”.) Opposition figures have been silenced, imprisoned and killed. Boris Nadezhdin, an anti-war politician, collected enough signatures to gain a place on the ballot, but was banned from standing. On February 16th Alexei Navalny, Russia’s most prominent opposition leader, died in the Siberian penal colony where he was incarcerated on spurious charges.

In that context, holding the vote may seem pointless. But the exercise is important to Mr Putin. His rule relies on carefully maintaining the appearance of popular support. The election is a ritualistic expression of that approval. It will embolden the president to continue his war in Ukraine and his campaign of repression at home.

Photo: EPA

## The collapse of India’s fintech star

For years, Paytm was the trailblazer in India’s booming fintech scene. The startup pioneered digital payments in the country, accumulating 100m active users and attracting billions in venture capital. In 2021 it went public at a valuation of $20bn, in what was then India’s biggest-ever IPO. These days, though, the company is struggling.

Paytm’s share price has slumped amid concerns over its profitability. And in trying to attract more users it has cut corners, angering regulators. On Thursday the firm is shutting its banking arm on the orders of India’s central bank because of “persistent non-compliances”, such as opening accounts without proper identification.

The crackdown will have far-reaching implications. Users with Paytm bank accounts, including many small businesses, will have to withdraw their money. Many of the other 7,000 fintech startups in India may have to tone down their similarly aggressive approaches to recruiting customers. Paytm’s success story has become a cautionary tale.

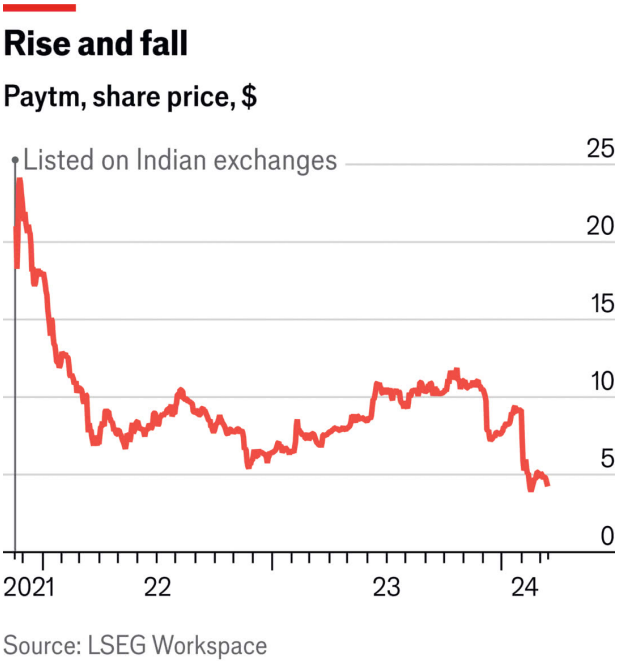

Photo: Getty Images

## Macron, Scholz and Tusk meet

When Emmanuel Macron, France's president, visits Berlin on Friday he will attempt to mend fences with Olaf Scholz, the German chancellor. The pair differ in temperament and political instinct—and in recent weeks they have also disagreed over the war in Ukraine.

Taking the Germans by surprise, at the end of February Mr Macron publicly mused that Western countries might send ground troops to Ukraine. Mr Scholz immediately rejected the idea. German officials were especially irritated by such hawkish talk as France has provided only €635m ($693m) in military aid to Ukraine, while Germany has delivered or promised €17.7bn, calculates the Kiel Institute for the World Economy (figures the French government contests.). Messrs Macron and Scholz will later be joined by Donald Tusk, the Polish prime minister, for a meeting of the Weimar Triangle, a geopolitical forum born in 1991 after the end of the cold war. Poland and Germany are particularly keen to resuscitate it.

Photo: © Amazon Prime

## Frida Kahlo, in her own words

Frida Kahlo is one of Mexico’s greatest cultural exports. She is Latin America’s most expensive artist, and the Blue House, her home in Coyoacán, is one of the most visited museums in Mexico City. Yet Kahlo is also revered as a feminist icon in a way oddly detached from her life and work. Her ubiquitous likeness—replete with her characteristic unibrow—adorns all manner of trinkets, including plates and socks.

“Frida”, a documentary released on Prime Video this week, uses Kahlo’s diaries and letters to tell her story in her own words. It covers the bus crash that nearly killed her at the age of 18, her tempestuous marriage to Diego Rivera, a fellow painter, and her affairs (among them one with Leon Trotsky). Throughout, her paintings and drawings are brought to life with careful animation. It is a vivid portrait of a singular artist, who strove to portray the world “through no one else’s eyes” but her own.

## Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each day this week. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and, as important, tell us the connecting theme. Email your responses (and include mention of your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to [email protected]. We’ll pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners on Saturday.

**Friday:** Which English county contains the cities of Portsmouth and Southampton?

**Thursday:** The white rose was the symbol of which English royal house?

*Dissents speak to a future age.*

*Ruth Bader Ginsburg*